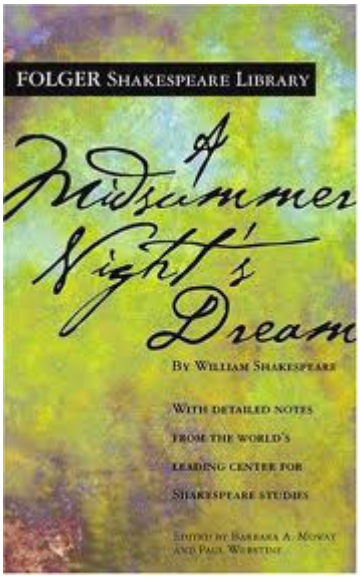
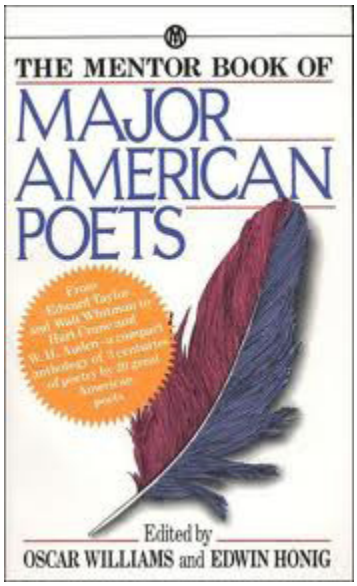
UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

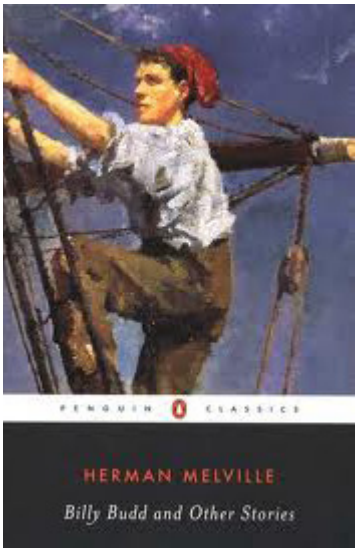
Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

District 1 • 2012







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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • District 1 • 2012

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. A poem expressing religious emotion and generally intended to be sung by a chorus is called a(n)

   A) ballad.
   B) chantey.
   C) epideictic poem.
   D) folk song.
   E) hymn.

2. The Texas-born short story writer and author of the novel *Ship of Fools* and the long short story "Pale Horse, Pale Rider" and whose Collected Short Stories earned her the 1966 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction is

   A) Harper Lee.
   B) Katherine Anne Porter.
   C) E. Annie Proulx.
   D) Alice Walker.
   E) Eudora Welty.

3. Writing that reads the same from left to right and from right to left is called a(n)

   A) anagram.
   B) boustrophedon.
   C) calligraphy.
   D) palindrome.
   E) zeugma.

4. The period in American literary history following the Civil War for which fiction became the effective voice of the new turbulence, the growing skepticism and disillusionment, and culminating with the publication of Dreiser's *Sister Carrie* is the

   A) Naturalistic and Symbolistic Period.
   B) Period of Conformity.
   C) Period of the Confessional Self.
   D) Realistic Period.
   E) Romantic Period.

5. The term applied to the many forms in which human beings have given rhythmic expression to their most intense perceptions of the world, themselves, and the relation of the two is

   A) anthology.
   B) chrestomathy.
   C) poetry.
   D) rhapsody.
   E) syncopation.

6. **Not** a generic term that describes, in some way, a published work is

   A) dime novel.
   B) page turner.
   C) penny dreadful.
   D) potboiler.
   E) voice-over.

7. The early-nineteenth-century utopian experiment in communal living initially sponsored by the Transcendental Club, whose members included, for a short time, Hawthorne, is known as

   A) Brook Farm.
   B) Graustark.
   C) Grub Street.
   D) Inns of Court.
   E) Waldon Pond.

8. The author of *Troilus and Cressida*, *All's Well That Ends Well*, and *Measure for Measure* is

   A) Francis Bacon.
   B) Ben Jonson.
   C) Christopher Marlowe.
   D) William Shakespeare.
   E) Edmund Spenser.

9. A figure of speech in which a similarity between two objects is directly expressed in a comparison that is usually introduced by *as*, *like*, *than*, *resembles*, or *compares*, among others, is a(n)

   A) analogy.
   B) metaphor.
   C) objective correlative.
   D) simile.
   E) tautology.

10. The Irish-British playwright whose *Arms and the Man*, *Mrs. Warren's Profession*, *Pygmalion*, and *Joan of Arc* earned him the 1925 Nobel Prize for Literature is

    A) Winston Churchill.
    B) Rudyard Kipling.
    C) Harold Pinter.
    D) Bertrand Russell.
    E) George Bernard Shaw.

11. The form of extended metaphor in which objects, persons, and actions in a narrative are equated with meanings that lie outside the narrative itself is

A) allegory.
B) allusion.
C) conceit.
D) metonym.
E) synecdoche.

12. The play for which playwright and essayist Arthur Miller was awarded the 1949 Pulitzer Prize for Drama is

A) *All My Sons*.
B) *The Crucible*.
C) *Death of a Salesman*.
D) *The Man Who Had All the Luck*.
E) *A View from the Bridge*.

13. An expression used during informal everyday conversation but not accepted universally in formal speech or writing is known as a(n)

A) barbarism.
B) colloquialism.
C) idiotism.
D) Marinism.
E) solecism.

14. The seventeenth-century poets who revolted against the conventions of Elizabethan love poetry, focusing instead on a psychological analysis of the emotions of love and religion are the

A) Cavalier Lyricists.
B) Fireside Poets.
C) Graveyard Poets.
D) Metaphysical Poets.
E) Spasmodic Poets.

15. Pure or serious comedy that appeals to the intellect and arouses thoughtful laughter by exhibiting the inconsistencies and incongruities of human nature and by displaying the follies of social manners is known as

A) boulevard drama.
B) *commedia dell'arte*.
C) high comedy.
D) low comedy.
E) satire.

16. **Not** one of the literary periods named after the reigning royal family and considered part of the English Renaissance is the

A) Caroline Age.
B) Early Tudor Age.
C) Edwardian Age.
D) Elizabethan Age.
E) Jacobean Age.

17. The twentieth-century Nigerian (British Commonwealth) author of *Things Fall Apart*, *No Longer at Ease*, and *Arrow of God* is

A) Chinua Achebe.
B) John Coetzee.
C) Nadine Gordimer.
D) Wole Soyinka.
E) Derek Walcott.

18. The author of *A Witness Tree* and *A Further Range* and four-time recipient of the Pulitzer Prize for Poetry (1924, 1931, 1937, 1943) is

A) Stephen Vincent Benét.
B) Robert Frost.
C) Robert Lowell.
D) Edwin Arlington Robinson.
E) Wallace Stevens.

19. The system of manners and morals associated with the feudal system of the Middle Ages and presented in medieval romance in a highly idealized form is known as

A) arabesque.
B) chivalry.
C) feudalism.
D) pastoral.
E) virelay.

20. A term that has come to be used for a historical legend developed until it was accepted as true—a form lying between authentic history and intentional fiction that tells of heroic achievement or adventure—is

A) folklore.
B) folktale.
C) legend.
D) myth.
E) saga.

21. The belief that everything partakes of a hierarchical system, extending upward from inanimate matter, to things that have life but do not reason, to the rational human being, to angels, and finally to God is

A) Baconian Theory.
B) Freytag's Pyramid.
C) The Great Chain of Being.
D) Grimm's Law.
E) Ockham's Razor.

22. A word formed by combining the initial letters or syllables of a series of words to form a name is a(n)

A) acronym.
B) allonym.
C) eponym.
D) heteronym.
E) pseudonym.

23. **Not** a term that describes a particular use of words or a language specific to a particular population or profession is

A) dialect.
B) idiom.
C) jargon.
D) koine.
E) neologism.

24. The term applied to women of pronounced intellectual interest that gained currency after 1750 as a result of its application to a London group of women of literary and intellectual tastes who held meetings to which literary men were invited is the

A) Bloomsbury Group.
B) Bluestockings.
C) Della Cruscans.
D) Geneva School.
E) Hermeneutic Circle.

25. The poet whose *Essay on Criticism*, *The Rape of the Lock*, *Essay on Man*, *Epistle to Dr. Arbuthnot*, and translations of Homer contribute to his being one of the most quoted of literary personages is

A) Daniel Defoe.
B) John Dryden.
C) Samuel Johnson.
D) Alexander Pope.
E) Jonathan Swift.

26. The term usually applied to a group of early-twentieth-century Southern American writers in Nashville, Tennessee, who published the little magazine entitled *The Fugitive* is

A) Agrarians.
B) Beat Generation.
C) Knickerbocker Group.
D) Muckrakers.
E) Transcendental Club.

27. Poems, including epics and ballads, that tell a story are called

A) alliterative verse.
B) *carmen figurata*.
C) narrative poems.
D) nursery rhymes.
E) reporting poems.

28. The Native American author and recipient of the 1969 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for his novel *House Made of Dawn* is

A) Saul Bellow.
B) Michael Chabon.
C) Oscar Hijuelo.
D) Larry McMurtry.
E) N. Scott Momaday.

29. The group of late-nineteenth- and early-twentieth-century writers, principally in France but also in England and America, who held that art is superior to nature and that the finest beauty is that of dying and decaying things is the

A) Aesthetes.
B) Decadents.
C) Imagists.
D) Parnassians.
E) Physiocrats.

30. The concept that the theatre can demonstrate human beings' inescapable enslavement to things, whereby the theater becomes a ceremonial act of magical purgation, is known as (the)

A) *commedia dell'arte*.
B) liturgical drama.
C) Theater in the Round.
D) Theater of Cruelty.
E) Theater of the Absurd.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-37 are associated with William Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream*.
Items 38-45 are associated with Herman Melville's *Billy Budd, Sailor, An Inside Narrative*.
Items 46-50 are associated with Marianne Moore's poetry (selected).

31. In William Shakespeare's *Midsummer Night's Dream* the lines "I have a widow aunt, a dowager / Of great revenue, and she hath no child. / From Athens is her house remote seven leagues [. . .]" is spoken by
    A) Bottom to Flute.
    B) Demetrius to Helena.
    C) Lysander to Helena.
    D) Lysander to Hermia.
    E) Pyramus to Thisbe.

32. The soliloquy in which the words "Things base and vile, holding no quantity, / Love can transpose to form and dignity. / Love looks not with the eyes but with the mind; / And therefore is winged Cupid painted blind" is spoken by
    A) Demetrius.
    B) Helena.
    C) Hermia.
    D) Hippolyta.
    E) Lysander.

33. Thisbe's request upon finding Pyramus, "O Sisters Three, / Come, come to me / With hands as pale as milk" is addressed to the
    A) Fates.
    B) Furies.
    C) Graces.
    D) Mechanicals.
    E) Muses.

34. Bottom's offering to wear a "French-crown-color beard" constitutes an
    A) addendum.
    B) allusion.
    C) anachronism.
    D) apostrophe.
    E) axiom.

35. Titania's romantic declaration "Thou art as wise as thou art beautiful" is directed at
    A) Bottom.
    B) Demetrius.
    C) Hippolyta.
    D) Oberon.
    E) Robin.

36. The exchange between Quince, who says, "[H]e is a paramour for sweet voice" and Flute, who chides, "You must say 'paragon.' A 'paramour' is (God bless us) a thing of naught" turns on a
    A) malapropism.
    B) mondegreen.
    C) pun.
    D) solecism.
    E) Spoonerism.

37. Lysander asks, "Who will not change a raven for a dove?" Continuing, he contends that the "will of man is by his reason swayed, / And reason says you are the worthier maid," which confirms that he has
    A) confused women with birds.
    B) fallen in love with Hermia.
    C) found a way to argue his case with Egeus.
    D) succumbed to Robin's potion.
    E) trusted his emotions.

38. In Melville's *Billy Budd* the contrast offered by the simile "incongruous as a musket would be on the altar at Christmas" describes
    A) the ship's captain.
    B) the ship's chaplain.
    C) the ship's master-at-arms.
    D) the ship's purser.
    E) the ship's surgeon.

39. Surprised at being called to the captain's cabin, Billy ventures the thought that he might
    A) be made Captain Vere's coxswain.
    B) be requested to spy on his fellow bluejackets.
    C) have to explain his conversation with the Dansker.
    D) have to go without a meal after spilling the soup.
    E) be returned to *The Rights of Man*.

40. The phenomenon being discussed by the purser and the surgeon after the execution is the
    A) appearance of the "vapory fleece" in the East.
    B) birds coming for the hanging body.
    C) injury that caused Claggart's death.
    D) lack of any spasmodic movement in Billy's body.
    E) name of the vessel that engages the *Bellipotent*.

41. The narrator notes that the average tar's own understanding of "human wickedness" limits his understanding to a personal knowledge of "*man-brokers* and *land-sharks* of the seaports," two terms for

A) foreign-born bluejackets.
B) impressment gangs.
C) mutineers.
D) Napoleonic sailors and soldiers.
E) naval lawyers.

42. Billy is told that it is the master-at-arms who is "at the bottom of [Billy's] strange experiences on board the *Bellipotent*" by

A) John Claggart.
B) the Dansker.
C) Captain Graveling.
D) Lieutenant Ratcliffe.
E) Edward Vere.

43. The narrator's qualifying remark "like the beautiful woman in one of Hawthorne's minor tales" is both

A) bombast and patronage.
B) hyperbole and understatement.
C) litotes and simile.
D) metaphor and paradox.
E) simile and allusion.

44. Claggart's remark "Handsome is as handsome did it, too!" follows

A) Billy's coming aboard the *Bellipotent*.
B) Billy's spilling his soup.
C) Claggart's arrival in Vere's cabin.
D) Ratcliffe's bringing Billy onto the *Bellipotent*.
E) Vere's requesting Claggart for an explanation.

45. Among the most significant of the many Biblical allusions that the narrator offers his audience is found in his comparing the relationship between Vere and Billy to

A) Abraham and Isaac.
B) Adam and Able.
C) Adam and Cain.
D) Moses and Joseph.
E) Noah and Ham.

Items 46-48 refer to Marianne Moore's

To a Steamroller

The illustration
is nothing to you without the application.
  You lack half wit. You crush all the particles down
    into close conformity, and then walk back and forth on them. 4

Sparkling chips of rock
are crushed down to the level of the parent block.
  Were not "impersonal judgment in aesthetic matters, a metaphysical impossibility," you 8

might fairly achieve
it. As for butterflies, I can hardly conceive
  of one's attending upon you, but to question
    the congruence of the complement is vain, if it exists. 12

46. The syllabic verse pattern of Marianne Moore's "To a Steamroller" is

A) 5, 12, 11, 1, 12, 3; 5, 12, 12, 15; 5, 12, 12, 13, 2.
B) 5, 12, 12, 13, 2; 5, 12, 12, 15; 5, 12, 12, 15.
C) 5, 12, 12, 15; 5, 12, 12, 15; 5, 12, 12, 15.
D) 10, 12, 11, 1, 12, 3; 5, 12, 12, 15; 5, 12, 12, 13, 2.
E) 10, 12, 12, 13, 2; 5, 12, 12, 15; 5, 12, 12, 15.

47. The figure of speech that carries the poem's tone is

A) apostrophe.
B) hyperbole.
C) irony.
D) paradox.
E) simile.

48. The persona's criticism of the steamroller—and who or what it represents—focuses on its crushing "down into close conformity" everything's and everybody's

A) butterflies.
B) parents.
C) particles.
D) sparkling personalities.
E) uniqueness.

Items 49-50 refer to Marianne Moore's

England

with its baby rivers and little towns, each with its abbey or its cathedral;
with voices—one voice perhaps, echoing through the transept—the
criterion of suitability and convenience; and Italy with its equal
shores—contriving an epicureanism from which the grossness has been

extracted, and Greece with its goat and its gourds, the nest of modified illusions:
and France the "chrysalis of the nocturnal butterfly," in
whose products, mystery of construction diverts one from what was originally one's
object—substance at the core: and the East with its snails, its emotional

shorthand and jade cockroaches, its rock crystal and its imperturbability,
all of museum quality: and America where there
is the little old ramshackle victoria in the south, where cigars are smoked on the street in the north;
where there are no proofreaders, no silk-worms, no digressions;

the wild man's land; grass-less, links-less, language-less country—in which letters are written
not in Spanish, not in Greek, not in Latin, not in shorthand
but in plain American which cats and dogs can read! The letter *a* in psalm and calm when
pronounced with the sound of *a* in candle, is very noticeable, but

why should continents of misapprehension have to be accounted for by the
fact? Does it follow that because there are poisonous toadstools
which resemble mushrooms, both are dangerous? Of mettlesomeness which may be
mistaken for appetite, of heat which may appear to be haste, no con-

clusions may be drawn. To have misapprehended the matter is to have confessed
that one has not looked far enough. The sublimated wisdom
of China, Egyptian discernment, the cataclysmic torrent of emotion compressed
in the verbs of the Hebrew language, the books of the man who is able

to say, "I envy nobody but him, and him only, who catches more fish than
I do"—the flower and fruit of all that noted superi-
ority if not stumbled upon in America, must one imagine
that it is not there? It has never been confined to one locality.

49. Marianne Moore's poem "England" is principally about
    A) America.
    B) Egypt.
    C) England.
    D) Greece.
    E) Italy.

50. Ultimately, the idea that drives the variety of comparisons finds a critical response in
    A) lines 3-10.
    B) lines 15-18.
    C) lines 18-19.
    D) lines 21-22.
    E) lines 25-26.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Item 51 refers to Paul Griffin's poem.

Euripides
Had grumbling insides:
Sometimes they were like a squadron of planes
And sometimes like the Frogs of Aristophanes.

51. The witty humor of Griffin's four-line poem is found in the expectation associated with
    A) airplanes.
    B) allusion.
    C) amphibians.
    D) auditory imagery.
    E) eye rhyme.

Items 52-55 refer to Molly Holden's

Some Men Create

Some men create an unintended
Beauty by default,
never cut back the creeping ivy
so its stragglers vault
from crumbling wall to neighboring bridge
beside the arched lane,
to swing like hair from the parapet,
shining with spring rain;
never gravel out the timber pile
nor lop the dead oak
so that the seeding traveler's joy
smothers them like smoke.
So among orderly husbandry*
leave some plots alone
that the eye may reap with pleasure what
the hand has not sown.

***orderly cultivation of plants**

52. In Molly Holden's "Some Men Create," "beauty by default" (line 2) means
A) made by man.
B) made by mistake.
C) made by nature.
D) made by travelers.
E) made by woman.

53. The poem's basic foot is the
A) anapest.
B) dactyl.
C) iamb.
D) spondee.
E) trochee.

54. The traveler's joy (line 11) is brought about by
A) finding a crumbling wall.
B) finding an orderly husband.
C) reaping what others have sown.
D) seeing something natural.
E) swinging from a parapet.

55. Ultimately, the advice to the gardener constitutes a(n)
A) ambiguity.
B) hyperbole.
C) oxymoron.
D) paradox.
E) pun.

Items 56-59 refer to Ben Jonson's

Simplex munditiis*

Still* to be neat, still to be dressed,
As you were going to a feast;
Still to be powdered, still perfumed*:
Lady, it is to be presumed,
Though art's hid causes are not found,
All is not sweet, all is not sound.
Give me a look, give me a face,
That makes simplicity a grace;
Robes loosely flowing, hair as free:
Such sweet neglect more taketh me
Than all the adulteries* of art;
They strike mine eyes, but not my heart.

*** the title means 'simple in elegance'**

*** still means 'always'**

*** the poem was written in the early seventeenth century when taking a bath was not part of a person's daily routine**

*** adulteries means 'infidelities,' thus 'deceptions'**

56. Thematically, Ben Jonson's "*Simplex munditiis*" focuses on the difference between
A) appearance and reality.
B) art and clothing.
C) eyes and hearts.
D) looks and faces.
E) perfumes and robes.

57. The poem's basic metrical pattern is
A) dactylic trimeter.
B) iambic pentameter.
C) iambic tetrameter.
D) trochaic pentameter.
E) trochaic tetrameter.

58. The phrase "sweet neglect" is to be recognized as
A) allegorical.
B) euphemistic.
C) hyperbolic.
D) oxymoronic.
E) paradoxical.

59. The persona's opinion of "art" is that it is
A) dressed.
B) false.
C) feminine.
D) simple.
E) sweet.

Items 60-63 refer to
Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's

Possibilities

Where are the Poets, unto whom belong
The Olympian heights; whose singing shafts were sent
Straight to the mark, and not from bows half bent,
But with the utmost tension of the thong?
Where are the stately argosies of song,
Whose rushing keels made music as they went
Sailing in search of some new continent,
With all sail set, and steady winds and strong?
Perhaps there lives some dreamy boy, untaught
In schools, some graduate of the field or street,
Who shall become a master of the art,
An admiral sailing the high seas of thought,
Fearless and first and steering with his fleet
For lands not yet laid down in any chart.

60. Longfellow's "Possibilities" represents the
A) caudate sonnet.
B) curtal sonnet.
C) Italian sonnet.
D) Shakespearean sonnet.
E) Spenserian sonnet.

61. The sonnet's volta, its turn in thought, occurs at the beginning of
A) line 4.
B) line 5.
C) line 8.
D) line 9.
E) line 12.

62. The "possibilities" are founded in the questioning formula "Where are they?" which is known as
A) *carpe diem*.
B) *memento mori*.
C) *ubi sunt*.
D) *vade mecum*.
E) *verbum infans*.

63. The poem's sestet suggests promise might exist
A) in an art school.
B) in uncharted lands.
C) in unexpected places.
D) on a ship.
E) on the high seas.

Items 64-65 refer to Robert Graves's

Song: One Hard Look

Small gnats that fly
In hot July
And lodge in sleeping ears,
Can rouse therein
A trumpet's din
With Day-of-Judgement fears.

Small mice at night
Can wake more fright
Than lions at midday.
An urchin small
Torments us all
Who tread his prickly way.

A straw will crack
The camel's back,
To die we need but sip,
So little sand
As fills the hand
Can stop a steaming ship.

One smile relieves
A heart that grieves
Though deadly sad it be,
And one hard look
Can close the book
That lovers love to see—

64. The litany of contrasts that make up Robert Graves's "One Hard Look" moves from
A) figurative to literal.
B) frightening to prickly.
C) large to small.
D) mythical to natural.
E) small to large.

65. The poem's imagery suggests that the persona has discovered that
A) hearts are jealous.
B) incidental things have consequences.
C) Judgment Day is near.
D) lovers are fickle.
E) urchins, mice, gnats, and camels are troubling.

Tie-breaking essay prompt on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie.

Note well: Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided for this essay; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Marianne Moore's "Silence," and discuss the poem's tone—its attitude toward visitors, focusing on both the comparison made by the persona's father and on his declaration (borrowed from the eighteenth-century British statesman Edmund Burke), "Make my house your inn," as well as on the persona's own statement, "Inns are not residences."

Silence

My father used to say,
"Superior people never make long visits,
have to be shown Longfellow's grave
nor the glass flowers at Harvard.
Self-reliant like the cat—
that takes its prey to privacy,
the mouse's limp tail hanging like a shoelace from its mouth—
they sometimes enjoy solitude,
and can be robbed of speech
by speech which has delighted them.
The deepest feeling always shows itself in silence;
not in silence, but restraint."
Nor was he insincere in saying, "Make my house your inn."
Inns are not residences.

University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest
District 1 • 2012
KEY

Page numbers are those associated with the *Handbook* 11e, the Penguin 1986 edition of *Budd*, and the Folger edition of *MND*.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History

30 items (1 point each)

1.	E	278	11.	A	14	21.	C	256
2.	B	661	12.	C	664	22.	A	4
3.	D	394	13.	B	110	23.	E	368
4.	D	458	14.	D	342	24.	B	71
5.	C	425	15.	C	269	25.	D	609+
6.	E	577	16.	C	198	26.	A	12
7.	A	78	17.	A	642	27.	C	361
8.	D	601	18.	B	662	28.	E	661
9.	D	514	19.	B	98	29.	B	151
10.	E	657	20.	E	489	30.	D	143

Part 2: UIL Reading List

20 items (2 points each)

31.	D	1.1.159-61	38.	B	374	45.	A	367
32.	B	1.1.238-41	39.	A	348	46.	C	
33.	A	5.1.353-55	40.	D	376	47.	A	40
34.	C	1.2.89-91	41.	B	316	48.	E	
35.	A	3.1.150	42.	B	336	49.	A	
36.	A	4.2.11-14	43.	E	302	50.	D	
37.	D	2.2.121-23	44.	B	322			

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism

15 items (2 points each)

51.	E	220	56.	A		61.	D	577
52.	C		57.	C		62.	C	566
53.	C	282	58.	D	392	63.	C	
54.	D		59.	B		64.	E	
55.	D	398	60.	C	300	65.	B	

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Marianne Moore's "Silence"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

allusion,
ambiguity,
ambivalence,
imagery,
irony,
litotes,
simile, and
tone.

The young writer might focus solely on the simile, pointing to the grimness or the morbidity of the image of a cat with a dead mouse in its mouth. The comparison of superior people to cats that seek out solitude, which is a fairly natural comparison, is made specific, if not memorable, with the reason for the cat's having sought solitude: the capture of something it wants. The father's noting that superior people might find solace ("enjoying solitude)" in taking for their own someone else's words ("robbed of speech / by speech which has delighted them") might be recognized as ironic: the persona, the daughter (?), has appropriated the father's words. Thus the poem's tone might be understood in terms of the daughter's take on the quality of her father's advice. The poem's autobiographical nature sets up an ambiguity for the reader meeting the poem for the first time. Any discussion of the poem's tone or the persona's attitude toward her father or her father's advice might be a bit off target; this should not be a problem, however; any discussion of tone that depends on support directly from the poem should be deemed literary analysis.

The competitor might focus on the poem's last line, which seems to be a defiant contradicting of the line borrowed from Burke, "Make my house your inn." A discussion of the poem's tone that begins with the persona's seeming contracting of her father's maxim-like invitation might recognize the simile's morbidity and perhaps make something of the inherent morbidity of "Longfellow's grave." Such an approach to the poem might point to a significance of the silence of the grave, the silence of the cat's mouth, and the active silence of restraint (line 12). The tone then depends on recognizing the last line as a rejection. "Inns are not residences" suggests a loud negating of the silence that seems to please the father.